SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #2 · GOD

“If there is a God, he would not let this happen.”

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Where it often comes from

A painful loss, illness, betrayal, injustice, or abuse that seemed senseless. Prayers for protection or healing that were not answered the way you hoped. Teaching that faithful Christians will be kept from hardship, or that enough faith guarantees a good life. Never being taught what the Bible actually says about suffering. Anger at God that never felt safe to say out loud.

What Scripture teaches

The Bible never promises a life without pain. Jesus told His followers plainly, “In this world you will have trouble.” Suffering does not prove that God is absent or unreal. Much of it comes from living in a fallen world and from the free choices of people, and God grieves it too. He entered our suffering Himself in Christ, He is close to the brokenhearted, and He works even in painful things for the good of those who love Him. One day He will wipe away every tear. Until then, Scripture invites you to bring Him your honest questions and grief.

> *“I have told you these things, so that in me you may have peace. In this world you will have trouble. But take heart! I have overcome the world”* **(John 16:33)**.

Also see

> “The LORD is close to the brokenhearted and saves those who are crushed in spirit” **(Psalm 34:18)**.

> “And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose” **(Romans 8:28)**.

> “How long, LORD? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?” **(Psalm 13:1)**.

> “He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away” **(Revelation 21:4)**.

Common self-statements

- A loving God would never allow this.
- Where was God when this happened?
- If God were real, He would have stopped it.
- Either God doesn’t care, or He isn’t there.
- My prayers didn’t work, so maybe faith is a lie.
- I can’t trust a God who lets things like this happen.

Common logical errors

- **False expectation:** Assuming that God promised a life without pain, when Scripture says the opposite.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Concluding “Either God prevents my suffering, or He doesn’t exist or doesn’t care.”
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I feel abandoned, so God must be absent or unreal.”
- **Jumping to conclusions:** Deciding what God’s silence means before the story is finished.
- **Mental filter:** Focusing on this one painful event while overlooking the ways God has been present in your life.

- **Overgeneralization:** Treating one unanswered prayer as proof that faith itself does not work.

Challenging questions

- Where did I get the idea that God promised to keep all pain away from me?
- Did Jesus, the apostles, and other faithful people suffer? What did that mean about God?
- Is it possible for God to be real and good and still allow suffering He did not cause?
- How much of this pain came from people's choices or a broken world rather than from God?
- Has God been present in my pain in ways I have overlooked?
- Am I judging the whole story before it is finished?
- What would it look like to bring this grief honestly to God, the way the Psalms do?

Truth summary

> My suffering does not prove that God is absent or unreal. Jesus told me I would have trouble in this world, and He has overcome it. God is close to me when I am brokenhearted, He works in all things for my good, and one day He will wipe away every tear. I can bring Him my honest questions and grief, and trust Him even when I do not understand.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- Hardship
- Troubles
- Grief
- Doubt
- Faith

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Trouble/Hardship
- Belief/Salvation

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If there is a God, he would not let this happen"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If there is a God, he would not let this happen." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I learn that God promised me a pain-free life?
- ☐ Did Jesus and other faithful people suffer too?
- ☐ Can God be real and good and still allow suffering?
- ☐ Did this pain come from God, or from people and a broken world?
- ☐ Has God been present in my pain in ways I overlooked?
- ☐ Am I judging the whole story before it is finished?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Suffering does not prove that God is absent.
- ☐ Jesus said I would have trouble, and He has overcome the world.
- ☐ God is close to me when I am brokenhearted.
- ☐ God can bring good out of even this.
- ☐ I can bring God my honest questions and grief.
- ☐ One day God will wipe away every tear.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **John 16:33**
  "I have told you these things, so that in me you may have peace. In this world you will have trouble. But take heart! I have overcome the world."
- [ ] **Psalm 34:18**
  "The LORD is close to the brokenhearted and saves those who are crushed in spirit."
- [ ] **Romans 8:28**
  "And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose."
- [ ] **Psalm 13:1**
  "How long, LORD? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?"
- [ ] **Revelation 21:4**
  "He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Evidence log:** Each day, write down one way God was present or helped me, even in this pain.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 34:18 becomes: "The LORD is close to **Sarah** when **she** is brokenhearted, and saves **her** when **she** is crushed in spirit."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write God an honest letter** about what happened and how you feel, the way David did in the Psalms.
- ☐ **Read the Book of Job,** or Psalms 13, 22, and 88, and notice how God's people brought their pain and questions to Him.
- ☐ **Talk with a pastor or trusted Christian friend** who has walked through suffering, and ask how they held on to God.
- ☐ **Make a "then and now" list** of hard times in your past and any good, help, or growth that came later.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If there is a God, he would not let this happen": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A way God was present today
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If there is a God, he would not let this happen.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, help me reject the lie that You cannot be real if You allow this pain. You know how much this hurts. Thank You that You are close to the brokenhearted and that Jesus has overcome the world. Hold me when I do not understand, and help me trust You until the day You wipe away every tear. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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